1. The Digital Nation Race

Question

What is one thing your government does better than the rest of the world, and one thing you would copy from another country?

Powerful answer

“If I had to identify one thing Kenya does exceptionally well, I would say we understand that digital government must reach ordinary people—not just people sitting in government offices.”

Look at Kenya's digital payments ecosystem, mobile technology and the evolution of eCitizen. We have demonstrated that technology can move government services from a physical queue to a citizen's phone.

And I would take that lesson all the way down to **Nyandarua**.

A farmer in Kinangop should not have to travel to Ol Kalou simply to find out the status of a government service. A young person in Ndaragwa should not need to know which office contains a particular form. Government should come to the citizen digitally.

But there is something I would copy from Estonia: interoperability.

Estonia's strength is not simply having many digital services. It is that government systems can securely communicate with one another through its X-Road infrastructure. (e-Estonia)

Kenya has started moving in that direction, but our next leap should be from digitising services to connecting government systems.

My vision for Nyandarua would be simple: **one citizen, one verified identity, one government experience.**

Punchline:

“Kenya has shown Africa that we can put government in the citizen's pocket. Our next challenge is making government systems talk to each other.”

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2. From Digital Government to AI Government

Question

How much decision-making should governments actually hand over to AI?

Powerful answer

> **“I would not give AI the government. I would give AI the ability to help government make better decisions.”**
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> There is a very important difference.
>
> AI can analyse thousands or millions of records much faster than a human being. In Nyandarua, for example, AI could help identify patterns in agricultural production, predict disease outbreaks, analyse revenue collection, identify areas experiencing service-delivery problems or help allocate resources based on evidence.
>
> But I would draw a red line around decisions that directly affect a person's fundamental rights, livelihood or freedom.
>
> **AI can recommend. Humans must remain accountable.**
>
> Imagine an AI system recommending that a particular citizen should not receive a government benefit. Who does that citizen appeal to? Who explains the decision? Who is responsible if the algorithm is wrong?
>
> Therefore, my model would be:
>
> **AI analyses. AI recommends. Humans decide.**
>
> And every significant AI decision should be explainable, auditable and appealable.
>
> Kenya is already pursuing digital-government transformation that includes shared government architecture, interoperability and cybersecurity safeguards. (KDEAP)
>
> **The next step is ensuring that AI becomes a servant of citizens, not an invisible authority over citizens.**

Punchline:

> **“I trust AI with the numbers. I don't give AI the final word on human beings.”**

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3. One Citizen, One Identity, One Experience

Question

> Can governments eliminate fragmented ministries, portals and processes and create a truly unified citizen experience?

Powerful answer

“Yes—and I believe Kenya has already shown that it is possible. But we have not finished the journey.”

From the citizen's perspective, government should not be organised according to ministries.

The citizen doesn't wake up saying:

Today I need to interact with Ministry X, Department Y and County Directorate Z.

They simply say:

“I need a birth certificate.”

“I need a business permit.”

“I need healthcare.”

“I need to register my business.”

The technology behind the scenes should be government's problem—not the citizen's.

Kenya's eCitizen model is already moving toward a single account for government services, while ICTA's strategy explicitly targets unified digital government delivery and interoperability. (ICT Authority)

For Nyandarua, I would take this further.

Imagine a farmer having one verified digital profile. That profile could securely connect relevant government services—agriculture, permits, payments, social programmes and other services—without the farmer repeatedly submitting information government already possesses.

Government should follow the principle: collect information once, use it responsibly many times.

That's one of the lessons we can learn from Estonia's “once-only” approach. (e-Estonia)

Punchline:

“Government should be organised around the citizen's life—not around the government's filing cabinets.”

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4. Sovereign Data vs Borderless Economy

Question

Where should national data sovereignty end and global digital interoperability begin?

Powerful answer

“Kenya should not choose between sovereignty and interoperability. We need both.”

Sovereignty means Kenya must know where its critical national data is, who can access it, why they can access it and under what law.

But sovereignty should not become digital isolation.

Think about a Kenyan company doing business with Uganda, Rwanda or Tanzania. If every country creates a completely isolated digital ecosystem, the East African digital economy becomes unnecessarily expensive and slow.

So my principle would be:

Protect the data. Connect the systems.

Critical government and citizen data should have strong Kenyan legal and security protections. But appropriately governed data exchange should be possible across borders where it creates economic or public value.

Kenya's digital transformation agenda already recognises the importance of interoperability, data governance and secure cross-border data flows. (KDEAP)

This is especially important for Nyandarua because our economy does not stop at the county boundary. Our farmers, businesses, students and workers participate in national and regional markets.

The future is not a world without borders. It is a world where borders no longer unnecessarily stop digital services.

Punchline:

“Data sovereignty should protect citizens—not imprison data inside government silos.”

5. When a Digital Nation Goes Down

Question

Are governments genuinely prepared for a large-scale cyberattack on critical digital infrastructure?

Powerful answer

“The honest answer is: no government should ever claim that it is completely prepared.”

Cybersecurity is not a destination. It is an arms race.

The more Kenya digitises, the more attractive our systems become to attackers.

And this is where the conversation becomes very real for Nyandarua.

Imagine waking up one morning and the county revenue system is unavailable.

Hospitals cannot access critical digital records.

Government payments cannot be processed.

Citizens cannot access online services.

That is no longer an IT problem.

That is a governance crisis.

Therefore, every digital government system needs three things:

Prevention. Detection. Recovery.

We need strong identity management, encryption, backups, monitoring, incident-response teams, disaster-recovery sites and regular cyber exercises.

Kenya's ICT strategy specifically identifies cyber resilience, incident response, security standards and secure digital infrastructure as priorities. (ICT Authority)

But I would add something very important:

We should design government systems on the assumption that one day something will fail.

The question is not *“Can we prevent every attack?”*

The question is:

“When the attack happens, how quickly can we restore essential services?”

Punchline:

“A secure government is not one that never goes down; it is one that can fall, recover and continue serving its citizens.”

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6. The Government of 2035

Question

What part of government as we know it today will completely disappear within the next decade?

Powerful answer

“The government office as the default gateway to government will disappear.”

Not government itself.

Not public servants.

But the idea that you must physically enter a government building to access government services.

By 2035, many routine services should happen automatically or digitally.

A young person in Nyandarua should be able to access government services from a smartphone.

A farmer should receive relevant agricultural information digitally.

A business should obtain permits without carrying files between offices.

Citizens should be able to track applications in real time.

And instead of government waiting for citizens to discover what they are entitled to, government should increasingly become **proactive**.

Kenya's current digital-government direction already focuses on moving services online and expanding access through digital channels. (ICT Authority)

But there is another institution I believe will shrink dramatically:

the paper file.

The future government record should be digital, secure, searchable, auditable and accessible to authorised people regardless of which office they sit in.

For a county like Nyandarua, that could dramatically change how citizens interact with health, agriculture, revenue, licensing, education and other county services. The county itself identifies digitisation of county systems and digital-economy transformation as priorities. (Nyandarua County Government)

Punchline:

“By 2035, the most successful government office may be the one the citizen never has to visit.”

CLOSING QUESTION

Question

If you became CIO of another country tomorrow, what ONE digital capability would you take from your country, and what ONE would you steal from another nation?

Powerful Grand Finale answer

“From Kenya, I would take mobile-first digital government.”

Kenya has demonstrated something incredibly powerful: technology does not have to wait for perfect infrastructure before it can transform people's lives.

We built a culture around mobile phones, mobile money and digital transactions, and that gives Kenya a unique advantage when designing citizen services.

If I became CIO of another country tomorrow, I would take that philosophy with me:

Build for the phone in the citizen's hand—not just the computer on the government officer's desk.

But from Estonia, I would steal **interoperability**.

Estonia demonstrates what happens when government systems are designed to securely communicate rather than operate as isolated islands. (e-Estonia)

And if I could combine those two ideas, this would be my vision:

Kenyan mobile-first accessibility + Estonian interoperability.

Then I would bring that vision back to Nyandarua.

Because the real definition of a digital nation is not how many computers government owns.

It is how little effort a citizen has to make to access government.

And ultimately, technology should not make government look more sophisticated.

It should make the citizen's life easier.

Final mic-drop line

“The government of the future will not be the government with the most technology. It will be the government that makes technology almost invisible—and makes public service almost effortless.”
